

MOVING TO New Battlegrounds

The ideology that drives global terrorists remains.
The world must learn to fight them in newer realms.

By Peter Clarke |

The first decade of the 21st century will be remembered not only as the period when terrorism moved on to a new level of barbarity, but also as the time when it became a strategic threat to democracies. In the 20th century, terrorism was very often driven by local, national or regional issues. There was frequently an accompanying political agenda that could, at least, form the basis for negotiations. That has changed. We are now challenged by a global movement, fuelled by an implacable ideology, which is not underpinned by any remotely achievable political agenda.

In the United Kingdom this change was particularly clear as we moved from an era of Irish terrorism into one where the overwhelming threat came from Islamists. The Irish terrorist threat, deadly though it was, actually operated within a set of parameters. So, although there were terrible atrocities committed during the campaign, the terrorists deliberately limited casualties as a means of maintaining a degree of public support and, therefore, leverage within a process of political negotiation. By contrast, those who have plotted and launched attacks in the UK under the Islamist banner have sought one thing—to kill as many people as possible. And this is a pattern we have seen repeated across the globe, not least in Mumbai on 26/11.

This change has profound implications for counter-terrorism. The scale of the threat to the public is so great that every opportunity must be seized to frustrate and defeat the terrorists. We used to think it was good practice to keep terrorists under surveillance, and try to capture them as they carried out their attacks. This tactic would allow us to develop really strong evidence against them. Whenever possible, that is still the case. Prosecution through the criminal courts is overwhelmingly the preferred way of dealing with terrorists.

However, because the scale of the threat to the public is now so great, we can't take any risks. If there is any danger that a group of terrorists might evade surveillance and launch an attack, they must be intercepted and disrupted, even if that means foregoing some valuable evidence against them. This

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- The September 11, 2001 attacks in the US which combine airplane hijacks with suicide pilots is the single largest terrorist attack in history. It was carried out by Al Qaeda, an organisation that had its roots in the proxy war between the US and the USSR in Afghanistan.
- The December 2001 attack on Parliament sees terrorism moving out of Jammu and Kashmir into India's hinterland, a trend that still continues.
- The US has lost 5,295 soldiers in Iraq and Afghanistan since 2001. In contrast, the 9/11 attack killed 2,976 persons.

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ORDER FOREVER

